

The Question of Philosophy: Spinoza, Descartes, and Husserl on What It Means to Philosophize

The question “what is philosophy?” is deceptive in its simplicity. No philosopher answers it directly, as if offering a definition to be memorized and repeated. Instead, each philosopher answers it by doing something—by enacting a transformation of the self, a method of inquiry, or a reorientation of the whole of human knowledge. For Spinoza, philosophy begins in the recognition of ordinary life’s hollowness and the decision to seek a true good that yields eternal joy. For Descartes, philosophy is the radical, once-in-a-lifetime demolition of all inherited opinions and the rebuilding of knowledge from the indubitable foundation of the thinking self. For Husserl, philosophy is the discipline of transcendental self-responsibility, the *epoche* that suspends naive acceptance of the world and uncovers the constituting life of the transcendental ego. Each of these three philosophers answers the question “what is philosophy?” not by telling us what it is, but by showing us what the philosopher must do, each revealing a different vision of philosophy’s necessity, its significance, and its intrinsic fascination.

Spinoza: Philosophy as the Emendation of the Intellect and the Pursuit of the True Good

Spinoza’s *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect* opens not with an abstract inquiry into the nature of knowledge, but with a confession. He writes: “After experience had taught me the hollowness and futility of everything that is ordinarily encountered in daily life, and I realised that all the things which were the source and object of my anxiety held nothing of good or evil in themselves save in so far as the mind was influenced by them, I resolved at length to enquire whether there existed a true good, one which was capable of communicating itself and could alone affect the mind to the exclusion of all else.”¹ Philosophy, for Spinoza, begins in a crisis of value. The ordinary pursuits of wealth, honor, and sensual pleasure are exposed as hollow. The philosopher is the one who sees through this hollowness and decides to seek a good that is permanent, shareable, and capable of producing “continuous and supreme joy to all eternity.”²

What makes this a philosophical decision rather than merely a practical one is that it requires a transformation of the intellect itself. Spinoza insists that we cannot simply decide to love eternal things, we must first “devise a method of emending the intellect and of purifying it, as far as is feasible at the outset, so that it may succeed in understanding things without error and as well as possible.”³ Philosophy is this method of emendation. It is the deliberate, self-aware correction of our cognitive habits so that we may perceive things adequately rather than through hearsay, casual experience, or confused inference.

¹Benedict de Spinoza, *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect*, in *The Ethics; Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect; Selected Letters*, trans. Samuel Shirley (Indianapolis: Hackett, 1992), 233.

²Spinoza, *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect*, 233.–

³Spinoza, *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect*, 236.

The core of Spinoza's answer lies in his famous classification of four modes of perception. He writes:

"If I examine them carefully, they can all be classified under four headings. 1. There is the perception we have from hearsay, or from some sign conventionally agreed upon. 2. There is the perception we have from casual experience; that is, experience that is not determined by intellect, but is so called because it chances thus to occur, and we have experienced nothing else that contradicts it, so that it remains in our minds unchallenged. 3. There is the perception we have when the essence of a thing is inferred from another thing, but not adequately. ... 4. Finally, there is the perception we have when a thing is perceived through its essence alone, or through knowledge of its proximate cause."⁴

Philosophy, for Spinoza, is the discipline of recognizing that only the fourth mode yields adequate knowledge. The first mode (hearsay) gives us no essence at all, we believe something only because someone else said it. The second mode (casual experience) yields only accidents and surface properties, not the thing itself. The third mode (inference) may produce truths, but not the essence of the thing inferred. Only the fourth mode "comprehends the adequate essence of the thing, and is without danger of error."⁵

Thus the significance of philosophy lies in its power to reorient the whole person toward what is eternal. Spinoza argues that "all happiness or unhappiness depends solely on the quality of the object to which we are bound by love."⁶ If we love perishable things, we will experience strife, sorrow, envy, and fear. But "love towards a thing eternal and infinite feeds the mind with joy alone, unmixed with any sadness."⁷ For Spinoza, philosophy is the method by which we learn to love what is eternal, not by suppressing desire, but by directing it toward its proper object. The intrinsic fascination of philosophy, for Spinoza, is that it promises a joy that never turns into its opposite, a happiness that does not depend on fortune or the opinions of others. It is the pursuit of the true good, and that pursuit is philosophy itself.

Descartes: Philosophy as Foundational Reconstruction from the Cogito

Descartes answers the question "what is philosophy?" with a dramatic gesture of demolition and rebuilding. The *Meditations on First Philosophy* begins: "Several years have now passed since I first realized how numerous were the false opinions that in my youth I had taken to be true, and thus how doubtful were all those that I had subsequently built upon them. And thus I realized that once in my life I had to raze everything to the ground and begin again from the original foundations, if I wanted to establish anything firm and lasting in the sciences."⁸

⁴Spinoza, *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect*, 237.

⁵Spinoza, *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect*, 239.

⁶Spinoza, *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect*, 234–235.

⁷Spinoza, *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect*, 235.

⁸René Descartes, *Meditations on First Philosophy*, Meditation I, 17.

Philosophy, for Descartes, is the radical act of foundation-laying. It is not a matter of adding new beliefs to old ones, or of refining existing opinions. It is the decision to doubt everything that can possibly be doubted, so that what remains will be absolutely certain. This is why the First Meditation is not a skeptical exercise for its own sake but a necessary purgative: the philosopher must withdraw assent from the senses, from the body, from the external world, and even from mathematical truths, at least until they can be secured against the possibility of a deceiving God or an evil genius.

What survives this universal doubt is the cogito: “I am, I exist—this is certain. But for how long? For as long as I am thinking; for perhaps it could also come to pass that if I were to cease all thinking I would then utterly cease to exist.”⁹ The philosopher is the one who discovers that the thinking self is the Archimedean point of all knowledge. From this foundation, Descartes proceeds to prove the existence of God (as no deceiver) and then to establish the reliability of clear and distinct perception, the existence of the external world, and the real distinction between mind and body.

The significance of philosophy for Descartes is that it alone can provide the certainty that the sciences require. He writes: “The certainty and truth of every science depends exclusively upon the knowledge of the true God, to the extent that, prior to my becoming aware of him, I was incapable of achieving perfect knowledge about anything else.”¹⁰ Without philosophy, we are left with mere opinion, vulnerable to doubt at any moment. With philosophy, we can achieve “full and certain knowledge about countless things, both about God and other intellectual matters, as well as about the entirety of that corporeal nature which is the object of pure mathematics.”¹¹

The intrinsic fascination of Cartesian philosophy lies in its radical self-sufficiency. The philosopher does not rely on tradition, authority, or the senses. He withdraws into solitude, shuts his eyes, stops his ears, and converses only with himself. And from that solitary withdrawal, he produces the foundations of all knowledge. There is something both terrifying and exhilarating about this vision: the philosopher stands alone against the possibility of universal deception, and by the sheer force of clear and distinct perception, he wins certainty. Descartes’ answer to “what is philosophy?” is that it is the most demanding and most rewarding human activity, the activity of grounding everything on the self’s own evident insights.

Husserl: Philosophy as Transcendental Self-Responsibility through the Epoche

Husserl’s Cartesian Meditations takes up Descartes’ project but radicalizes it. Husserl agrees that philosophy must begin with a radical withdrawal into the self and a rejection of naive acceptance. But he argues that Descartes did not go far enough; he remained trapped in

⁹Descartes, *Meditations*, Meditation II, 64.

¹⁰Descartes, *Meditations*, Meditation V, 92.

¹¹Descartes, *Meditations*, Meditation V, 92.

“transcendental realism,” treating the ego as a *substantia cogitans*—a little piece of the world—rather than as the transcendental source of all sense and validity.

For Husserl, philosophy is the discipline of the *epoche*—the phenomenological reduction that suspends all naive belief in the existence of the world. He writes: “If I put myself above all this life and refrain from doing any believing that takes ‘the’ world straightforwardly as existing — if I direct my regard exclusively to this life itself, as consciousness of ‘the’ world — I thereby acquire myself as the pure ego, with the pure stream of my cogitationes.”¹² Philosophy is not the discovery of a foundation within the world (like Descartes’ thinking substance) but the discovery that the world itself. Its sense, its validity, its very being—derives from the transcendental ego’s constituting life.

Husserl diagnoses the crisis of contemporary philosophy as a loss of the spirit of radical self-responsibility. He writes: “Instead of a unitary living philosophy, we have a philosophical literature growing beyond all bounds and almost without coherence. ... The philosophers meet but, unfortunately, not the philosophies. The philosophies lack the unity of a mental space in which they might exist for and act on one another.”¹³ Philosophy has become a mere semblance of philosophizing, a pseudo-reporting and pseudo-criticizing that lacks genuine collaboration toward objective truth. Against this, Husserl insists that philosophy must recover the “radicalness of self-responsibility” that animated Descartes—not to adopt Descartes’ content, but to renew his spirit with greater intensity.

The significance of philosophy for Husserl is that it alone can overcome the naive objectivism that dominates the sciences and everyday life. The natural attitude takes the world as simply there, existing independently of the knower. But the phenomenological *epoche* reveals that the world is always a world for me, constituted in and through my conscious life. Philosophy is the rigorous science of this transcendental subjectivity. It is the discipline that uncovers the “acceptance-basis of all Objective acceptances”¹⁴ the transcendental ego that bears the world as an accepted sense.

The intrinsic fascination of Husserlian philosophy is that it promises to return us to “the things themselves” not by escaping subjectivity but by plumbing its depths. The *epoche* is not a loss of the world but a gain: we acquire the world as phenomenon, as sense constituted, and we acquire ourselves as the transcendental source of that sense. Philosophy is the endless task of describing the structures of consciousness that make any experience of a world possible. It is the most radical form of self-examination, not the psychological introspection of the isolated individual, but the transcendental uncovering of the conditions for objectivity as such.

¹²Edmund Husserl, *Cartesian Meditations: An Introduction to Phenomenology*, trans. Dorion Cairns (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1960), 21.

¹³Husserl, *Cartesian Meditations*, 5.

¹⁴Husserl, *Cartesian Meditations*, 26.

Hegel: Philosophy as a Form of Actual Knowing

Hegel believes that he is on the very forefront of a philosophical revolution. He believes that past philosophical work was centered around a love and passion for knowledge, rather than an actual form of knowledge itself. Hegel sees his work as the missing piece for the field of philosophy, allowing for philosophy to mature from a passion of knowing to actual knowing through a scientific system of sorts. Hegel states that “The true shape in which truth exists can only be its scientific system. The goal I set myself is to contribute to bringing philosophy nearer to the form of science—to help it renounce its name as love of Knowing, and become actual Knowing.”¹⁵

Philosophy for Hegel shares two different paradigms. On the one hand, he still views the philosophical work that comes before him as philosophy, yet his work is meant to bring a whole new era of philosophy. While this may seem contradictory at first, Hegel does not view it this way. Instead Hegel brings in a metaphor of a flower bud, flower and fruit. “The bud disappears in the eruption of the flower, so one could say that the flower contradicts the bud. In a similar way, the fruit declares the flower to be the plant’s false existence, and steps forward in its place as the plant’s truth. These forms are not only distinct; they reject one another as mutually exclusive. At the same time, their fluid nature makes them into moments of an organic unity, in which they not only do not struggle with each other, but one is as necessary as the other; and only this equal necessity constitutes the life of the whole.”¹⁶ In other words, Hegel views the work before him as necessary and a part of philosophy despite potentially contradicting his own beliefs on philosophy. As such, although the different definitions of philosophy are contradictory, he still views this as the start of a new philosophical era.

The significance of philosophy for Hegel is that it is the only way to find truth, similar to Spinoza in some odd way. Hegel believes that “The true shape in which truth exists can only be its scientific system”¹⁷, with its scientific system being philosophy itself. In the act of genuine philosophical thinking, the content unfolds its own immanent logic, and that unfolding is the system. The system is not a static framework but the living, dialectical process of the matter’s own becoming. This is why Hegel insists that the whole is “the result together with its becoming”¹⁸.

Conclusion: Visions of Philosophy

Spinoza, Descartes, Husserl, and Hegel each answer the question “what is philosophy?” by showing what the philosopher must do. For Spinoza, the philosopher is one who recognizes the hollowness of ordinary pursuits, emends the intellect, and learns to love the eternal. Philosophy is the pursuit of the true good, a transformation of desire that yields joy unmixed with sadness.

¹⁵G. W. F. Hegel, Preface to the Phenomenology of Spirit, Excerpts, in Text and Running Commentary, 71.

¹⁶Hegel, Preface, 66-67.

¹⁷Hegel, Preface, 71.

¹⁸Hegel, Preface, 69.

For Descartes, the philosopher is one who razes everything to the ground, doubts all that can be doubted, and rebuilds knowledge from the indubitable foundation of the thinking self. Philosophy is the radical grounding of the sciences in self-evident truths. For Husserl, the philosopher is one who performs the epoche, suspends naive acceptance of the world, and uncovers the transcendental ego as the source of all sense and validity. Philosophy is transcendental self-responsibility, the rigorous science of consciousness. Hegel believes that philosophy before him falls short by falling victim to the love of knowing and not actually knowing. Hegel believes philosophy is the process and result of seeking truth. Despite their differences, all four share a common conviction: philosophy is not a body of doctrines to be learned but an activity to be performed. It begins in a decision to seek the true good, to doubt, to suspend acceptance. And it transforms the one who practices it. The question “what is philosophy?” is therefore not a question that can be answered by a definition. It can only be answered by the act of philosophizing itself.